THE PROTEIN GOLD RUSH

India's protein-based food market is growing at a furious pace, as FMCG firms and a host of startups rush to tap the rising demand from health-conscious customers. But not all of it is healthy, say experts

BY **SONAL KHETARPAL**

WHEN INFLUENCER REVANT HIMATSINGKA, BETTER KNOWN AS FOODPHARMER, RAN AN INSTAGRAM POLL IN MARCH 2024, asking "what's missing from your diet?", over 70 per cent of the 2,974 respondents came up with the same answer: protein. Once a staple of gym-goers trying to bulk up, millions of consumers are now watching their protein intake and asking for healthy products without compromising on taste. While growing health awareness and rising disposable incomes are driving the trend, influencers and celebrities gushing on social media about how they have made a higher protein intake a part of their lifestyle is fuelling its expansion. And it's not just health food startups like Yoga Bar, Troovy, The Whole Truth, SuperYou and Protein Chef who are supplying the goods, legacy players in the food and beverage industry have joined the protein race too. On the table are protein-enhanced idlis, biscuits, dairy products, bread, ice cream, coffee and even protein water. Swiggy now lists more than a million protein-rich dishes, McDonald's offers a plant-based protein slice in its burgers and Nestlé has launched besan Maggi noodles. Protein is

Bagrry's

Whey protein muesli with chocolate, rolled oats, high-protein oats

6

High-protein products, also includes dark chocolate high-protein oats, makhana, trail mix

ITC

Aashirvaad high-protein atta, soya chunks, organic moong dal

7

Includes chakki khapli atta, Svasti milk & dahi, ITC Right Shift high-protein oats

■ Top protein products
■ Products launched



SuperYou

Protein wafers, wafer minis, protein powders